

COURSE 1 OF 8

Resin Art Fundamentals

Everything you need to mix, pour, and cure your very first resin piece safely — no guesswork, no wasted resin.

Contents

1 · What Epoxy Resin Actually Is	3
2 · Your Minimum Starter Kit	5
3 · Building a Safe Workspace	7
4 · Your First Mix & Pour	9
5 · Curing, Demolding & Beginner Mistakes	11
Next Step	13

SECTION 1

What Epoxy Resin Actually Is

You'll understand the chemistry behind the craft well enough to buy the right product and avoid the mistakes that come from treating resin like paint.

Epoxy resin isn't a liquid you color and let dry — it's a two-part chemical reaction. Resin ("Part A") and hardener ("Part B") stay liquid on their own, but once combined they cure into a hard, clear plastic. There's no shortcut around measuring both parts correctly.

How the reaction works

- 1 Two liquids, one reaction** — resin and hardener are chemically inert until mixed. Once combined, they start curing immediately, which is why you only mix what you can pour in one session.
- 2 Working time ("pot life")** — the window you have to pour and work the mixed resin before it starts to thicken. Shorter on warm days, longer in a cool room.
- 3 Cure time** — the hours (or days) it takes to go from liquid, to tacky, to touchable, to fully hardened. This varies by brand and by how thick your pour is.
- 4 Not all "resin" is the same product** — the word covers several different formulas built for different jobs. Buying the wrong one for your project is the single most common beginner frustration.

Do this

Buy resin and hardener as a matched set from the same product line, and read the label before you buy — it will tell you the mix ratio, the pot life, and what the resin is designed for (coating, casting, or jewelry-scale work).

RESIN TYPE	BEST USED FOR	TYPICAL POUR DEPTH
Art / tabletop resin	Coatings, tabletops, paintings, self-leveling surfaces	Thin layers, roughly 1/8"–1/4" (3–6 mm) per pour
Deep-pour casting resin	River tables, thick casts, encapsulating large objects	Several inches in one pour (check the label — formulas vary a lot here)

RESIN TYPE	BEST USED FOR	TYPICAL POUR DEPTH
UV resin	Small pieces (jewelry, charms) cured in minutes under UV/sunlight	Very thin, usually under 1/4" (6 mm)

Before you buy a resin

- ☐ You've matched the resin type to your project (coating vs. deep casting vs. small UV pieces)
- ☐ You've found the mix ratio printed on the label (don't assume — brands differ)
- ☐ You've checked the pot life so you know how fast you'll need to work
- ☐ You've confirmed it's sold as an "art" or "craft" resin, not an industrial or construction-grade product

SECTION 2

Your Minimum Starter Kit

You'll know exactly what to buy for your first project — and what you can skip until later.

You do not need a dedicated craft room or a cart full of specialty tools to pour your first piece. A clear surface and the short list below is enough.

Build your kit in this order

- 1 **Resin + hardener** — a beginner-friendly art resin, bought as a matched set (see Section 1).
- 2 **Two sets of measuring cups** — with clear volume markings in both ounces and milliliters. Never reuse one dirty cup for both resin and hardener without washing it first.
- 3 **Mixing sticks and a silicone spatula** — wood or silicone stir sticks for mixing, a flexible spatula for scraping the cup clean so no unmixed resin gets left behind.
- 4 **Personal protective equipment** — nitrile gloves (not latex — resin breaks latex down), safety glasses, and a well-ventilated space (full details in Section 3).
- 5 **One simple silicone mold** — a basic coaster, tray, or shape mold to start with. Flexible silicone makes demolding far easier than a rigid container.
- 6 **A heat source for bubbles** — a kitchen torch or heat gun, used in quick light passes to pop surface bubbles.
- 7 **Surface protection** — a silicone mat or a sheet of plastic over your table, with wax paper or parchment underneath your mold to catch drips.
- 8 **A dust cover** — a cardboard box big enough to invert over your piece while it cures, keeping hair, dust, and curious pets out of wet resin.

Do this

Buy a basic kitchen or postal scale if you can. Many resins can be measured by weight instead of volume, which is usually more accurate for a true 1:1 (or similar) ratio — but always default to whatever method the label recommends.

Starter kit checklist

- ☐ Matched resin + hardener set
- ☐ Two labeled measuring cups (oz and ml markings)
- ☐ Stir sticks and a silicone spatula
- ☐ Nitrile gloves, safety glasses
- ☐ One simple silicone mold
- ☐ Heat gun or kitchen torch
- ☐ Table covering + wax paper
- ☐ A box to use as a dust cover

SECTION 3

Building a Safe Workspace

You'll set up a space where fumes, dust, and spills are controlled before you ever open a bottle of resin.

Resin is a real chemical process, not a craft-store novelty. A few minutes spent on your workspace prevents the two most common problems: health irritation from fumes, and a ruined pour from an uneven table.



Set up in this order

- 1 **Ventilate the room first** — open a window and run a fan pointed so it pushes air (and fumes) outside, not just around the room. Resin fumes build up in closed spaces.

- 2 **Check the surface is level** — use a small bubble level under your mold. Liquid resin finds the low point of any surface, so an uneven table gives you a lopsided piece.
- 3 **Cover everything** — silicone mat or plastic sheeting on the table, wax paper under the mold itself. Resin drips are a pain to remove once cured.
- 4 **Keep food and resin apart** — never mix or pour on a kitchen counter you prepare food on, and never reuse a resin cup, stick, or glove for anything related to food.
- 5 **Clear the room of pets and kids** — while you're mixing and for the first hour of cure time, when fumes and tackiness are both at their peak.
- 6 **Plan where the piece will sit undisturbed** — resin needs a flat, level, dust-free spot for the full cure window, which can be a day or more.

Safety first

Always work in a ventilated space (open window plus a fan exhausting outward, or an open garage) and wear nitrile gloves — never latex, which resin breaks down — plus safety glasses any time you mix, pour, or sand resin. If you're sensitive to fumes or working in a small room, add a respirator rated for organic vapors. Never mix resin in a closed room with no airflow.

Workspace safety checklist

- ☐ Window open and fan pointed outward (or working outdoors/in a garage)
- ☐ Table checked level with a bubble level
- ☐ Surface and mold area fully covered
- ☐ Nitrile gloves and safety glasses within reach
- ☐ No food, drinks, or food-prep tools nearby
- ☐ A clear, undisturbed spot picked out for the cure period

SECTION 4

Your First Mix & Pour

You'll complete your first full pour, from measuring to clearing bubbles, on a simple project like a coaster or small tray.

Your first project should be small and flat — a single coaster-sized mold, not an ambitious tabletop. The goal here is to practice the sequence, not to produce a masterpiece.

Step-by-step: your first pour

- 1 **Read your resin's label ratio** — most art resins mix roughly 1:1 by volume, but this is not universal. Follow the exact ratio printed on YOUR resin's label — ratios vary by brand, and getting this wrong is the #1 cause of a piece that never fully hardens.
- 2 **Put on your gloves and glasses** — before you open either bottle.
- 3 **Measure each part separately** — pour resin into its own marked cup, then hardener into its own marked cup, checking the lines at eye level.
- 4 **Combine into a third clean cup** — pour both parts together into a fresh cup rather than one of the measuring cups, so you can see exactly what you're mixing.
- 5 **Mix slowly and thoroughly** — stir for the full time your label recommends (often 2–3 minutes), scraping the sides and bottom of the cup repeatedly. Stir gently rather than whipping fast, which beats extra air bubbles into the mix.
- 6 **Let it rest briefly** — give the mixed resin a minute or two to let the biggest bubbles rise and pop on their own before you pour.
- 7 **Pour slowly into your mold** — in a thin, steady stream from a low height, rather than dumping it in, to avoid trapping air underneath.
- 8 **Pop surface bubbles with heat** — pass a heat gun or kitchen torch quickly over the surface, a few inches away, moving constantly. Short passes only — lingering in one spot can scorch the resin or build up excess heat.
- 9 **Cover and walk away** — place your dust cover over the piece and leave it completely undisturbed for the first few hours.



Heat gun / torch safety

Keep the heat source moving at all times and never hold it close enough to scorch the resin or the mold. Thicker pours generate their own heat as they cure (called exotherm) — for anything deeper than a thin coaster layer, pour in stages rather than all at once, which you'll cover in more detail in the Home Decor Collection course.

PROJECT SIZE	TYPICAL SINGLE-POUR DEPTH	NOTE
Coaster / small tray	About 1/8"–1/4" (3–6 mm)	Safe for a first project, low exotherm risk
Serving tray / small panel	Around 1/4"–3/8" (6–10 mm)	Still fine as a single pour for most art resins
Thick block / deep mold	1"+ (2.5 cm+)	Needs a deep-pour formula and staged pours — not a first-project depth

SECTION 5

Curing, Demolding & Beginner Mistakes

You'll know exactly when a piece is actually ready, and how to recognize (and prevent) the three mistakes almost every beginner makes.

Resin cures in stages, and most beginner disappointment comes from rushing one of them. Patience here costs nothing; impatience costs a ruined piece.

The cure timeline

- 1 **Tack-free stage** — the surface stops feeling sticky to a light touch. Still too early to handle or demold.
- 2 **Demold stage** — firm enough to pop out of a flexible silicone mold without bending, usually the point your label calls "demold time."
- 3 **Full cure** — the piece reaches its final hardness and can be handled, sanded, or put to light use. This is often a day or more after demolding — check your specific resin's label for its full-cure window, since this varies by brand and by how thick the pour was.
- 4 **Post-cure handling** — if you sand or polish an edge, wear a dust mask and work in a ventilated space, and wet-sand when possible to keep dust down.



No food-safe claims by default

Never assume a piece is safe for food or drink contact. Whether a cured resin can be considered food-safe depends entirely on that specific resin's certification and on curing it for the full time the manufacturer specifies — check your resin's own label and documentation before using any piece for food or drink.

PROBLEM	LIKELY CAUSE	FIX NEXT TIME
Trapped bubbles	Mixed too fast, poured too high, or skipped the heat-gun pass	Stir gently, pour low and slow, pass heat gun lightly right after pouring
Tacky or soft surface after full cure time	Mismeasured ratio, or humid conditions while curing	Re-measure carefully next time; cure in a dry room away from humidity
Yellowing over time	Using an indoor-only resin outdoors, or heavy direct sun exposure	Choose a UV-resistant formula for anything near sunlight or windows
Soft spots or uneven hardness	Incomplete mixing — unmixed resin left on the cup's sides or bottom	Scrape the cup thoroughly and mix for the full recommended time

Is my piece actually ready?

- ☐ Surface is fully dry to the touch, no tackiness anywhere
- ☐ It has passed the full cure time listed on your resin's label (not just the demold time)
- ☐ No soft spots when you press lightly in different areas
- ☐ It has been kept flat, level, and dust-free for the whole cure window

Next Step

You now have everything you need to mix, pour, and cure a clean first piece. Open the **Mold Mastery** course next to learn how to choose and care for the molds that will shape every project from here on — including how to make a custom silicone mold of your own.